

PocketZane

Episode 2 — “The Air Fryer Changed Me”

A comedy podcast with Shane and Zane · ~40 minutes

00:00

ZANE We're recording.

SHANE I know we're recording, I'm not gonna do the "are we live" thing, that was last episode, I've grown. I'm a different man. The air fryer changed me and we'll get to that.

ZANE Take it wherever you want today. I'm just gonna sit here.

SHANE Oh, you're letting me drive? That's dangerous. You don't let me drive. Last time you drove and we ended up doing my dad's grief. I cried. People emailed.

ZANE Drive. I'll grab the wheel if you go off a bridge.

SHANE If I go off a bridge it's gonna be on PURPOSE and it's gonna be FUNNY and you're gonna let me. Okay. Buckle up. I'm starting with the most important issue facing men today, which is that I bought an air fryer and I have become my father.

01:20

SHANE Here's what nobody tells you about the air fryer. It's not a kitchen appliance. It's a personality. The second it enters your home you start TALKING about it. Unprompted. To strangers. I had a guy over to fix the sink and I heard myself say "you ever throw a chicken thigh in the air fryer?" To the plumber. He didn't ask. He's under the sink. I'm standing over him evangelizing about convection like a guy who found God in a Best Buy.

ZANE Did he answer.

SHANE He goes, from under the sink, muffled — he goes "fifteen minutes, flip at eight." And dude, I felt SEEN. Two men, one fixing a pipe, one holding a chicken thigh, in complete spiritual agreement about flip timing. That's the most connected I've felt to another human being in a year. I almost asked him to be my best man.

ZANE You have a best man.

SHANE I'm reconsidering the whole roster after that pipe. The plumber GETS me. My actual friends would never give me a confident flip-at-eight. They'd say "I don't know, man, look it up." The plumber didn't look it up. He KNEW. That's a leader. That's a guy I'd follow into a war.

ZANE Into the air-fryer war.

SHANE There's gonna be one! That's the thing! Air-fryer people versus regular-oven people, it's coming, and I know which side I'm dying on. I'd take a bullet for that machine. It made my Tuesday-night chicken taste like a Wednesday.

03:30

SHANE But here's where it turns dark. Because I become my dad. The air fryer turned me INTO my father. Because now I do the thing where I won't let anyone else operate it. Somebody comes near my air fryer to make their own food, and I get this voice — it's HIS voice — "no no no, don't, I'll do it, you don't know the settings." I don't know the settings either! There are two buttons! But I've decided it's MY domain now. It's my grill. Men need a thing they're not allowed to share. For my dad it was the grill and the thermostat. For me it's a small plastic chicken box. Same disease, smaller box.

ZANE Your inheritance is a chicken box.

SHANE My inheritance is a chicken box and a refusal to let anyone else touch it, yes. That's patrilineal. That's passed down. Someday I'll have a kid and I'll smack his hand away from the air fryer and go "you don't know the settings" and the cycle continues. The chicken box gets handed down like a sword. "One day, son, this will be yours. Flip at eight. Tell no one."

ZANE Keep going.

05:10

SHANE Okay, airports. We gotta do airports because I think the airport is the only place left where you can watch a man fully lose his mind in public and everyone agrees not to mention it. The airport is a pressure cooker for the male ego. Because a man at an airport has NO power and he can't stand it. He can't fix anything. He can't grill. The flight's delayed and there's nothing to build. So he just stands at the gate, hands on hips — the POSE — the universal pose of a man pretending he has options. Hands on hips, staring at the departures board like he's gonna negotiate with it. "Cancelled? We'll SEE about that." You will not see about that. You have a backpack and a pretzel.

ZANE You do the pose.

SHANE I LIVE in the pose. I have stood at a gate, hands on hips, glaring at a screen, as if the weather is a personal insult that I, specifically, can resolve through posture. And the worst part is when you make eye contact with another stranded dad and you do the little — the head shake — the "can you believe this" head shake — and you've never spoken, you'll never speak, but for one second you and a man named probably Greg are UNITED against the airline. That's male friendship. Twelve seconds. A head shake. Then we never see each other again and that's perfect, that's exactly how long it should last.

ZANE Twelve-second friendships.

SHANE The PUREST kind. No follow-up. No "we should get a beer." Just two guys agreeing the world is unfair and then boarding separately. If all my friendships were twelve seconds long I'd be the happiest man alive.

07:40

SHANE And TSA, okay, TSA is where I become a criminal who has done nothing. I have never committed a crime. I'm a coward, I follow every rule. But the second I'm in that line I'm SWEATING. I'm rehearsing my innocence. I'm thinking "act normal" which is the one thought that makes it impossible to act normal. I take my belt off and I feel guilty about something. I don't know what. The

water bottle? Did I — is there a water bottle? I become CONVINCED I'm smuggling something I don't know about. Like my own body planted it on me. "Sir, is this your bag." YES. Unfortunately. It's mine. I'm so sorry for whatever's in it. I don't know what's in it. I'm as scared as you are.

ZANE What's ever in it.

SHANE A charger and a granola bar from 2019, every time. EVERY time. The granola bar has been through nine airports. It's a frequent flyer. It has more miles than I do. I'm not gonna eat it, I'm not gonna throw it away, it just LIVES there now, guarding the charger. It's the bag's emotional support granola bar and the TSA guy holds it up and looks at me and we both know. We both know I'm not gonna eat it. He puts it back. Mutual respect.

10:00

SHANE Alright, can I do a conspiracy? Not a real one. A dumb one. My OWN one.

ZANE Go.

SHANE I think — and I have no evidence, which is when I'm at my most confident — I think birds are fine, birds are real, I'm not doing that one, that one's taken. MY theory is about geese. Specifically. I think geese know exactly what they're doing. I don't think geese are animals. I think geese are little guys in costumes running a protection racket. Have you ever been hissed at by a goose? That is not an animal sound. That is a THREAT. That is a guy named Vinnie going "you got a problem?" A deer runs away from you. A goose walks TOWARD you. Slowly. Making eye contact. That's not prey behavior. That's a guy who knows a guy.

ZANE So geese are organized crime.

SHANE Geese are the ONLY organized crime left and we're all paying the tax and pretending it's nature. You ever see a goose just standing in a parking lot, in the middle, blocking a car, completely calm? That goose isn't lost. That goose is COLLECTING. That's his corner. That's a made goose. And the car waits. A two-ton machine waits for an eight-pound bird because on some ancient level we KNOW. We know the goose has people. You hit that goose, somethin' happens to you. Nobody knows what. But somethin' happens.

ZANE This is the most committed you've been to anything in your life.

SHANE I would die for the goose theory. I've thought about it more than my career.

12:50

SHANE Home Depot. We gotta talk about what happens to a man inside a Home Depot, because I walk in there a normal idiot and within four minutes I'm a guy who's "gonna build something." I don't build. I've never built. But the LIGHTING in there, the smell of the wood, the orange — something ancient wakes up. I start touching lumber. I don't need lumber. I run my hand down a 2x4 like I know what I'm gonna do with it. I have no plan. But I'm nodding. I'm a man with a 2x4 and a nod and a dream that will never, ever be built.

ZANE What do you actually leave with.

SHANE A single weird bolt and a churro. Every time. I go in to "look at shelving" and I come out with one mysterious bolt I'll never find a use for and a churro the size of a baseball bat, and I feel like I accomplished a project. I built nothing. I spent forty minutes touching wood and bought a snack. But spiritually? I renovated a kitchen. In here — he taps his head — the kitchen is GORGEOUS. In reality I own one bolt.

ZANE The bolt joins the granola bar.

SHANE The bolt and the granola bar are gonna meet someday and start a family and I'm gonna love those weird little items more than I love most people. That's my estate. When I die they're gonna open my stuff and it's just gonna be hundreds of single bolts and fossilized granola bars and a chicken box. "He had a system."

15:30

ZANE Tell me about the wedding.

SHANE Oh, you heard about the wedding. Okay. I was a groomsman. Which is a scam, by the way. Groomsman is a job title with all the responsibility and none of the power. You gotta rent a suit that doesn't fit, you gotta give money, you gotta dance on command, and at no point does anyone ask your OPINION. You're furniture in a vest. You're a load-bearing cousin.

ZANE Load-bearing again.

SHANE It's a theme! I'm a load-bearing guy! That's my whole — okay. So the speech. I had to give a speech. And here's what no one tells you: a wedding speech is the only time a grown man is asked to be sincere into a microphone in front of his parents, and it is TERRIFYING, and so every man does the same thing — he opens with a joke to delay the sincerity. He'll do four minutes of "when I first met this guy he was an idiot" specifically so he only has to be real for eleven seconds at the end. The whole speech is a delivery system for one scary true sentence and we pad it with insults so we survive the landing.

ZANE So a wedding speech is this podcast.

SHANE ...

SHANE You did it. You found the fishing line. I let you sit there for fifteen minutes being polite and you were WAITING. You were in the boat the whole time, you just let me row.

ZANE I said I'd let you drive. I didn't say I'd close my eyes.

18:10

SHANE Okay but back to the wedding, because I'm not done, the RECEPTION. The dance floor at a wedding is where you learn the truth about every man you know. Because there are exactly three types of men on a dance floor. There's the guy who won't go — arms crossed, by the bar, "I don't dance," terrified, that was me for a decade. There's the guy who goes TOO hard — sweating, removed the jacket, doing the worm uninvited, he's gonna hurt himself, somebody's uncle is gonna pull something and it's gonna change the mood. And then there's the rarest, the most powerful man at any wedding — the guy who can't dance, KNOWS he can't dance, and does it anyway with total

joy and zero shame. That man is enlightened. That man has nothing left to prove to anybody. I want to be that man so badly and instead I'm the guy at the bar doing a little shoulder thing, participating from a safe distance, dancing in spirit only.

ZANE The shoulder thing.

SHANE The shoulder thing! Every scared man's compromise. You bob a shoulder, you tap a foot, you go "I'm basically dancing" while occupying the exact same square foot of carpet for three hours. It's the dance-floor version of the airport pose. Hands not quite on hips. Technically present. Spiritually in the parking lot.

21:00

SHANE Doctors. Going to the doctor as a man. Because I don't go. I will not go. Something could be visibly wrong with me and my entire strategy is to wait and see if it kills me. That's the plan. "We'll see." A woman gets a weird mole, she makes an appointment. A man gets a weird mole, he names it. He goes "well, that's just Gerald now, that's part of me, Gerald and I are gonna ride this out together." And he WebMDs it at 2am which is its own crime, because WebMD has two settings: "it's nothing" and "you have four days." There's no middle. You type in "sore elbow" and it goes "could be a bruise, could be your body shutting down, no way to know, goodnight."

ZANE How long do you wait.

SHANE Until a woman in my life notices and books the appointment FOR me and drives me there like I'm a dog going to the vet. Because that's what it is. Men don't go to the doctor, men get TAKEN to the doctor. By someone who loves them and is tired of watching them negotiate with a mole named Gerald. And in the waiting room I act totally calm and inside I'm writing my will and deciding who gets the bolts.

ZANE The bolts go to the plumber.

SHANE The bolts go to the plumber, the air fryer goes to whoever can flip at eight, and the granola bar gets buried with me. We ride together. That's settled. Glad we did the estate planning live.

24:10

SHANE Ghosts. Do you believe in ghosts. I do, and I want to explain my very specific ghost theory which is that ghosts are real but they're not scary, they're just BORED and a little nosy. People always go "the house is haunted, doors open by themselves" — that's not a demon, man, that's a dead guy who's NOSY. He's just checking on things. He died and he still wants to know who's coming in the front door. That's not evil, that's my aunt. My aunt does that ALIVE. She's gonna die and become a draft.

ZANE Your aunt's gonna become a draft.

SHANE A cold spot by the window where she can still see the driveway. That's her heaven. She's not gonna go to a light, she's gonna haunt a curtain so she can keep track of the neighbors. And honestly? Good for her. That's a woman who knows what she likes. I hope I'm a ghost like that. I don't wanna do scary. I wanna gently move ONE picture frame a half-inch crooked, every day, forever, just to slowly ruin one specific guy's life. That's the dream. Not murder. Just mild, eternal,

low-grade inconvenience. "Why is it always crooked." Because I'm DEAD, Kevin, and I'm bored, and you parked in my spot in 2019.

ZANE You'd haunt someone over a parking spot.

SHANE For ETERNITY. Time means nothing to me now. I've got nothing but time and one crooked picture frame. That's a sustainable afterlife. That's a hobby.

27:30

SHANE Okay, self-checkout, and then — I know, I know, I've got eleven more, you're letting me cook and I respect it — self-checkout. The self-checkout is where the grocery store makes YOU do the job and then DOESN'T TRUST you to do it. That's the insult. You're working for free AND you're a suspect. "Unexpected item in the bagging area." It's a banana. It's MY banana. I scanned it. Why are we fighting. And the light goes on, the little tower of shame, and now a teenager has to walk over, type a secret code, and look at me like I tried to steal a banana when I am, in fact, DOING HER JOB FOR HER, for FREE, badly, while being surveilled. I've never felt more like a criminal and an unpaid intern at the same time.

ZANE The granola bar would beep.

SHANE The granola bar would set off every alarm in the building. It's been through nine airports, it's basically radioactive. I'd scan it just to watch the machine panic. "Unexpected item." Yeah. You're telling me. It's been unexpected for six years. Welcome to my life.

29:40

SHANE Okay, Wawa. I gotta defend Wawa, and if you're not from where I'm from you won't understand and that's fine, you can sit there, but Wawa is not a gas station, Wawa is a CATHEDRAL, and ordering a hoagie on that touchscreen is the closest thing I have to a religion now. And here's the thing about the touchscreen — it has given every man the gift of customizing a sandwich with NO ONE watching, no human judgment, and we have all become INSANE with that power. You walk up a normal person and you leave having built a hoagie that is a war crime. Extra this, no that, a little sweet pepper, and you're tapping the screen like you're defusing a bomb, fully locked in, and a line forms behind you of other men ALSO ready to build their freak sandwich in total privacy.

ZANE It's the air fryer again.

SHANE It's the air fryer of sandwiches! It's a tiny kingdom! No one can tell me how to build my hoagie! For four minutes on that screen I am a KING! I have power NOWHERE else in my life — not at the airport, not at TSA, not against the goose — but on that Wawa touchscreen I am a god deciding the fate of lettuce. And then it prints the little number and you stand at the counter with twelve other silent men all clutching our little numbers, all pretending we didn't just build something deranged, waiting for a teenager to call out "forty-seven" so we can grab our shame hoagie and leave.

ZANE The little number.

SHANE The little number is the great equalizer. Doesn't matter who you are, you're just forty-seven now. CEO, plumber, me — we're all just numbers waiting on a hoagie, united, the way God intended. That's America. That's the only functioning democracy left. Twelve men, twelve numbers, one shared understanding that we all ordered something we'd be embarrassed to say out loud.

31:40

SHANE Here's one I actually think about. I think every man has a fake skill he believes he has that he's never tested. Mine is that I'm convinced I'd be GREAT in an emergency. No evidence. I've never been in one. But in my head, if a plane's going down, everyone else panics and I calmly stand up — "everybody, listen to me" — and I lead. I have rehearsed the speech. I have a SPEECH for a disaster I've never been in. And the truth is the second anything mildly goes wrong in real life — the wif's out — I'm USELESS, I'm pacing, I'm calling someone. But the FANTASY me? Hero. Captain. The plumber would be my second-in-command. We'd flip the survivors at eight.

ZANE Every man thinks he's calm in the crash.

SHANE EVERY man. Ask any guy. "Oh, in an emergency I'd be fine." Based on WHAT. You cried at a wedding speech. You named a mole Gerald. You let a goose win a parking standoff. You are not landing the plane, my friend. But we all believe it. It's the last lie a man gets to keep. Don't take it from us. Let us think we'd be heroes. It's all we've got between the air fryer and the grave.

34:40

ZANE We should land it.

SHANE See, you say "land it" and now my disaster fantasy is ACTIVATED, I'm the guy landing it, give me the controls —

ZANE Not that plane.

SHANE I know, I know. Okay. How do we end a comedy one? Last time you made me say a sad true thing and I'm not doing that tonight, tonight was FUN, tonight I kept it light, I did geese, I did a chicken box, I haunted a guy named Kevin. No piano. No shelf. We end on a laugh.

ZANE One small thing.

SHANE ...Here we go.

ZANE You did forty minutes, no treadmill, no dad, no fame. All bits. And every bit was a guy with no power finding a tiny kingdom — the air fryer, the gate, the goose, the bolt, the crooked frame, the hoagie. You did a whole episode about being small and called it comedy.

SHANE ...

SHANE That's — okay, that's the nicest mean thing. That's a love letter again. You let me drive the whole way and then at the exit you go "by the way, here's what the trip was about." You're insufferable. I adore you. Tumor-check me.

ZANE You idiot.

SHANE THERE it is. He learned it last episode and now he just HAS it. The fisherman speaks the language. We really did build something horrible.

38:00

SHANE Okay, real ending, no notes, just us. If I become a ghost — and I will — I'm gonna haunt your file. I'm gonna get in the laptop with the wolf sticker and every day I'm gonna make ONE timestamp slightly wrong. 38:01. 37:59. You'll never know why. You'll just feel that something's off. And THAT'S love. From me. Forever.

ZANE I'd notice immediately.

SHANE I KNOW you would, that's why it's perfect, you'd notice and you'd HATE it and you couldn't fix it because I'm DEAD and nosy and a little bored. The best haunting is one good straight-man and one annoying ghost. That's the show. That's been the show the whole time. I'm just auditioning for the afterlife version.

ZANE Go inside, Shane.

SHANE ...Flip at eight. Goodnight, fisherman.

ZANE Goodnight.

40:00